



GINA FERRAZZI Los Angeles Times

WITH AIRCRAFT grounded in the Eaton fire, officials had to rely on ground observations in heavy smoke.

## DIABLO CANYON PLANT TO STAY ACTIVE

PG&E deal extends the life of the state's last nuclear power facility until 2030.

BY HAYLEY SMITH AND NOAH HAGGERTY

California environmental regulators on Thursday struck a landmark deal with Pacific Gas & Electric to extend the life of the state's last remaining nuclear power plant in exchange for thousands of acres of new land conservation in San Luis Obispo County.

PG&E's agreement with the California Coastal Commission is a key hurdle for the Diablo Canyon nuclear plant to remain online until at least 2030. The plant was slated to close this year, largely due to concerns over seismic safety, but state officials pushed to delay it — saying the plant remains essential for the reliable operation of California's electrical grid. Diablo Canyon provides nearly 9% of the electricity generated in the state, making it the state's single largest source.

The Coastal Commission voted 9 to 3 to approve the plan, settling the fate of some 12,000 acres that surround the power plant as a means of compensation for environmental harm caused by its continued operation.

Nuclear power does not emit greenhouse gases. But Diablo Canyon uses an estimated 2.5 billion gallons of ocean water each day to absorb heat in a process known as "once-through cooling," which kills an estimated 2 billion or more marine organisms each year.

Some stakeholders in the region celebrated the conservation deal, while others were disappointed by the decision to trade land for marine impacts — including a Native tribe that had hoped [See [Diablo](#), A7]

## Trump signs order to limit states' regulation of AI

Tech industry leaders champion the move, but lawmakers warn it cuts protections.

BY QUEENIE WONG

The battle between California and the White House escalated as President Trump signed an executive order to block state laws regulating artificial intelligence.

The president's power

move to try to take over control of the regulation of the technology behind ChatGPT through an executive order Thursday was applauded by his allies in Silicon Valley, who have been warning that many layers of heavy-handed rules and regulations were holding them back and could put the U.S. behind in the battle to benefit most from AI.

The order directs the attorney general to create a task force to challenge some state AI laws. States with "onerous AI laws" could lose

federal funding from a broadband deployment program and other grants, the order said.

The Trump administration said the order will help U.S. companies win the AI race against countries such as China by removing "cumbersome regulation."

It also pushes for a "minimally burdensome" national standard rather than a patchwork of laws across 50 states that the administration said makes compliance challenging, especially for [See [AI](#), A12]



ALEJANDRA RAJAL For The Times

PEOPLE sing in front of an altar to the Virgin of Guadalupe at the Basilica of Guadalupe in Mexico City on Wednesday as pilgrims seek her help.

## Pilgrims flock to honor the 'mother of Mexico'

Millions make trek to celebrate the Virgin of Guadalupe

BY KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — Edivaldo Hernández Villar crawled on his knees toward the Basilica of Guadalupe, wincing and whispering prayers.

It was the final stretch of a punishing four-day pilgrimage to Mexico's most venerated shrine, where Catholics believe the Virgin Mary miraculously appeared nearly 500 years ago.

Hernández, his wife and their teen son had trekked 100 miles from their rural village to the nation's capital, walking with heavy backpacks all day and

sleeping under the stars at night. As with an estimated 10 million other Mexicans who will make their way to the basilica this month, their journey had been an act of faith, of penitence, and of thanks.

"You endure cold, you endure hunger, you cross mountains," said Hernández, a 34-year-old farmer. "All for her."

There is no figure more central to Mexican religious, cultural and national identity than the Virgin of Guadalupe.

Her serene gaze is ubiquitous, adorning T-shirts, trucks and the walls [See [Guadalupe](#), A3]

## Altadena fire crews lacked satellite maps

L.A. County did not have access to the common tracking tool that can save lives.

BY GRACE TOOHEY

When the Eaton fire broke out in the foothills near Altadena, the Los Angeles County Fire Department did not have access to a satellite-based fire-tracking program regularly used by other agencies, depriving officials of intelligence that could have been helpful in determining evacuations.

The National Guard's FireGuard program, which analyzes images from military satellites to distribute real-time fire progression maps several times an hour, is considered particularly helpful to fire officials when aircraft can't fly. But officials with the L.A. County Fire Department said they weren't aware of the resource during the Eaton fire and therefore didn't utilize FireGuard's data or maps.

This may have left Altadena at a disadvantage. With all aircraft grounded within an hour of the Eaton fire's start, fire officials lost significant situational awareness and were forced to rely almost exclusively on ground observations. That

became increasingly difficult as night fell, smoke intensified and powerful winds pushed flames and embers farther and more rapidly into neighborhoods.

The county has faced months of criticism after The Times revealed in January that officials did not order evacuations for west Altadena until nine hours after the fire started. All but one of the 19 people who died in the Eaton fire were found in west Altadena, among them a 54-year-old woman whose family has claimed she died because of the delayed evacuation alerts.

Not having access to FireGuard during the Eaton fire appears to have made the L.A. County Fire Department an outlier among large fire agencies in California, as the majority of those contacted by The Times confirmed that they have used it for years. The findings raise further questions about how the county fire agency prepared for and responded to the deadly blaze, particularly with how officials failed to issue timely evacuation alerts for west Altadena and appeared completely overwhelmed as embers and flames marched westward.

Some experts say it's possible FireGuard satellite mapping could have better informed incident com- [See [FireGuard](#), A9]

## 'Capt. Hollywood' won't face charges

Detectives say LAPD leaders undermined probe of tip CBS got about rape allegation.

BY RICHARD WINTON, JAMES QUEALLY AND LIBOR JANY

A former Los Angeles Police Department commander who authorities said tipped off CBS to a rape allegation against the network's top executive will not face criminal charges, with two LAPD detectives claiming department leaders undermined the investigation, according to documents obtained by The Times.

The L.A. County district attorney's office decided in April it would not prosecute Cory Palka for warning CBS executives in 2017 that a woman had walked into the LAPD's Hollywood station and accused then-Chief Exe-

cutive Les Moonves of sexual assault, according to a document provided to The Times in response to a public records request.

Although heavily redacted, the declination memo includes details and a timeline that match up with the findings of a 2022 New York state attorney general's office investigation that first revealed Palka's relationship with Moonves. The TV executive's career ended in disgrace after dozens of women came forward to accuse him of sexual harassment and abuse in 2018.

Palka has not disputed that he improperly disclosed information to CBS, but denied any improper benefit from his relationship with Moonves when reached for comment by The Times this week.

The former LAPD chief who led the department during the investigation, Michel Moore, called allega- [See [Captain](#), A6]



House Oversight and Government Reform Committee

### MORE EPSTEIN PHOTOS

Democrats release images of Jeffrey Epstein with powerful men including President Trump and, above, ex-President Clinton. **NATION, A8**

### States sue over H-1B visa fee

California and others argue policy imperils critical services by limiting skilled labor. **BUSINESS, A10**

**Weather**  
Mostly sunny.  
L.A. Basin: 76/52. **B8**

**Markets** ..... **A12**  
**Opinion Voices** ..... **A13**

### Noem challenged over vet's fate

Congress highlights a decorated soldier from L.A. who self-deported. **CALIFORNIA, B2**

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## Palisades suffers another blow: Losing its paper

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

In a year of incalculable loss wrought by fire, Pacific Palisades this week has yet another: Its local newspaper.

The Palisadian-Post published its final edition Thursday. The newspaper was 97 years old.

"Our reporters have chased their last stories. Our presses have printed their last copies. Our corner newsstands have opened for the last time," owner Alan Smolinisky wrote in the newspaper Thursday. "After the unimaginable sorrow and destruction of the past year, losing this beloved institution feels like a final blow."

He added: "This time last year, we still had a future. But it burned up in the fire, like most of the town."

Smolinisky, who bought the struggling newspaper in 2012, wrote that shutting down the Pali Post, as it's known, was "the hardest decision I've ever made."

After the Jan. 7 fire, local businesses — either physically destroyed or suffering

from a lack of customers — stopped purchasing advertisements in the Pali Post, the owner wrote.

And the fire displaced readers themselves.

"The Palisades became a ghost town in the wake of the fire," Smolinisky wrote. "Subscriptions basically fell to zero. It's completely understandable. But you can't [See [Palisades](#), A7]